

technology CYBER CRIME

PHISHING THE BOUNDARIES

India is now among the top 10 in Internet bank account hacking, with conmen deploying ingenious ways to siphon off your money

■ By Swagata Sen

The Internet has suddenly emerged as an easily accessible place to steal money and identities, as most users still operate through unsafe systems and are blissfully unaware of the dangers that lurk in cyber networks. The trouble is, Internet users are only as good as their password and i-pin. And phishing (Internet bank account hacking) is the way for miscreants and conmen to get hold of it. Internet users in India are being flooded by e-mails on millions of pounds or dollars they have either won or inherited. More serious are official-looking mails ostensibly from the bank where an Internet user has his or her account, saying the bank wants to crosscheck their personal data, account numbers and passwords. It looks official and appears to be exactly like your bank's website, but the moment you write in your personal data, the damage is done. A proxy server in any remote corner of the world, be it Nigeria or Taiwan, uses that information to then siphon off money from your account to theirs. It's that simple.

India has woken up to a plethora of phishing attacks in recent months. Last year, we were ranked 14th in phishing attacks worldwide, and this year we are in the top 10. The Bangalore police, for example, had registered over 40 cases of phishing last year. This year, there have already

been over 30 such cases registered. In November last year, Bangalore's Corps of Detectives arrested a man named Joseph Marci, who, between August 2006 and August 2007, had systematically bled 17 bank accounts in top commercial banks—including ICICI, HDFC, Axis and Citibank—siphoning small amounts regularly to have amassed Rs 3.54 lakh. It was an eye opener, as he used a simple tool that most Internet users could fall prey to. Marci's modus operandi was to download free software called "key logger" onto public computers in Bangalore's ubiquitous cyber cafes. Normally in the first week of the month, people check their bank accounts and type all their details. The software recorded the sequence of letters and numbers, giving Marci all the information he needed—bank account number, password, branch and so on.

A survey by Websense in 2007, which spoke to 450 cios (chief information officers) in India's biggest companies, revealed that 57 per cent of those companies had received phishing attacks, while 38 per cent had been attacked by a spyware, despite installing rigorous firewalls and anti-virus systems. And while most organisations were uncertain about the financial losses they incurred due to these attacks, about 55 per cent believed to have received viruses and worms into their network due to their employees surfing the net. The cios felt that some

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of the ways in which employees exposed their corporate networks to security threats included: free software downloads, use of Instant Messaging tools, proxy avoidance sites, visiting malicious websites and pop-up ads. Experts also say that the Internet Explorer, a browser that most of India uses, has no built-in anti-phishing mechanism. "Mozilla or Google's new

browser, Chrome, has anti-phishing tools, so it's you switch to them," says India's most famous cyberphishers. Fadia explains that plastic and e-money, which seems to be the most popular in India only in the last few years, this "could be a good tool for phishing and identity theft."

This identity theft takes many forms. Recently, there have been many incidents of

"IT Act lacks data theft provision; so nailing culprits is not easy."

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